

YouTube numbers

According to comScore, the web's leading video-streaming website crossed a hundred million unique viewers in the US



Superfast Chrome

Everyone on the web is gaga over the superfast new version of Chrome



Analytics Widget

Google now allows website owners to publish analytics

Agent 001

for *confiker* actually returned better results than the raining image search champion. As far as using Google Search as a spell checker, I used an application called Wordweb. It's a free dictionary and thesaurus that is far better than using Google. Just hit [Alt]+[Ctrl]+[W] to bring up the nifty little application from the task bar and query any word you want. You don't even have to get the spelling right, it'll give you suggestions just like Google does.

Gmail

Gmail is a tricky animal to live without. Many of us have already migrated to Gmail having still retained those old Yahoo, Hotmail or other inboxes. In such cases it shouldn't be a problem, just use a filter in Gmail to forward all your mail to another account, like I did. But what about those people who have started off with Gmail? They're far too used to the conversation style layout of Gmail which clubs relevant conversations together.

Several start pages such as Netvibes and Pageflakes provide a much better substitute to the iGoogle page. Netvibes also functions as a feed reader that has a lot of interesting preset news sources to choose from

Some are very comfortable with the labelling system (Though personally, I never did mind folders). Fear not, it's not as if there is no one out there who offers the same. Zoho Mail is a nice mail service that will give you much of the functionality of Google and will even let you access it using your existing Gmail or Yahoo account. In.com offers a small mail ID while giving you the conversation style system along with ample storage space. Mozilla's Thunderbird, though not technically web mail but a mail client, is another great alternative. It has the capability of adding plugins or extensions. Add in Lightning or Sunbird and you can even replace Google Calendar. If you prefer a web-based calendar app then 30 Boxes should work for you. It also integrates with Twitter and Facebook.

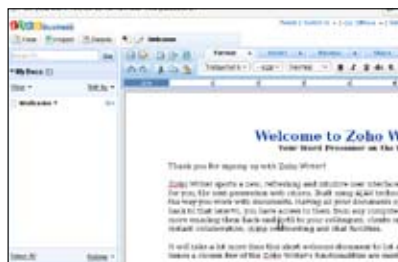
iGoogle

Another important Google service I use is the iGoogle start page. It is a customisable start page that lets you add news, photos, weather, and stuff from across the

web to a single page. Finding a replacement for this service was not at all a difficult task. Several players such as Netvibes, Shrt, Pageflakes and even MyYahoo and Microsoft Live provide start pages that are equally good and perhaps even better. I settled in on Netvibes.

Google Docs

This is perhaps the most non-trivial service Google is providing. It is definitely the most popular name when it comes to cloud-based office applications. But as with most things, popular isn't necessarily the best. Zoho offers office tools that are actually better. The word processor layout is very similar to MS Word and hence I found it pretty comfortable to use. The features offered by Zoho Writer are much better than Google Docs. Zoho allows you to post to your blog directly from within the feature rich Writer. Be it Blogger.com, Wordpress.com, LiveJournal, TypePad or any



Zoho Writer: A powerful online word processor and an able replacement to Google Docs

is, and it comes in the form of downloadable feed reader apps such as FeedDemon and Feedreader. Feed Demon has certain unique features such as "Watches" which are folders that aggregate current news for keywords automatically. Still, like me, if you are one of those who prefer online applications then you can use plugins for Firefox such as Sage or even the inbuilt feed aggregator for Opera. Or go in for popular options such as Bloglines or Netvibes which are essentially feed readers.

Google Maps

Google Maps has become one of the most used of its myriad services. I find myself depending on it quite heavily when planning my vacations. The product is no doubt superlative, but as always, there are options. There are the other web biggies – Microsoft's Virtual Earth and Yahoo Maps. Another forerunner in the online mapping space, and one that I found quite useful, is maps.ask.com. It has regular maps as well as satellite overlays, complete with driving instructions and distance calculator. Google Earth also has a rival in the form of Virtual Earth 3D – a Microsoft brainchild.

Google News

The whole world it seems has now got quite used to Google News. It's a good aggregator for reliable news from reputed sources. I found the new timeline feature quite interesting too. So if I am to look for an alternative for this particular tool, it had better

be good. My search led me to one of Google's biggest rivals – Live Search. But it turns out that the news section here is not available to people in this part of the world. So to get to it, you'll have to change your default location to United States. Very silly. It's a fairly decent option and I particularly liked the "More on this story" button which brings you similar news results. Just like Google News you have the option of browsing by categories such as entertainment, sport, sci-tech, health, and so on. Its news videos are quite relevant too. If you are looking for a fresh look like the Google Labs' timeline experiment, check out marumushi.com/apps/newsmap/ for an interesting way to depict news.

YouTube

But speaking of video, what am I going to do without my daily dose of YouTube? Obviously I'm overreacting. Between

Yahoo Video, Metacafe, Vimeo, Rewer, Blip.tv and Veoh I don't think I'll be missing YouTube anytime soon. In fact, looking elsewhere in this department might seriously be a refreshing experience. So moving on, for Orkut there's already FaceBook, for Picasa there's Flickr, and so on and so forth. The point is that without Google my life certainly did not come to a standstill. And neither will anyone else's. Sure Google has some superlative products but I don't need to be a willing participant in its increasing monoculture.

7 days later...

The week has finally ended and I've won the bet. This little experiment proved, if anything, that Google is good at most of what it does. But should the need for variety arise there are always options. Also, on a lighter note, if someone were to sabotage the multi-tentacled G monster, I'm probably the most prepared person there is. Now, so are you.